PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #75 · SUBSTANCE ABUSE

"This is the only thing that makes me feel okay, and nothing else will work."

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Where it often comes from

When something is the only thing that has made you feel okay, the mind draws a hard line: nothing else will work. Depression, panic, grief, and withdrawal can all make that line feel like a wall. It is a painful belief, and it is also a hopeless one. You are not foolish for having found one thing that numbed the pain. You are also not stuck with the conclusion that God, people, medicine, and time have nothing left for you. If this belief comes with thoughts of dying, that is an emergency, not a private philosophy. Please tell someone today. If you want help, call the SAMHSA National Helpline at 1-800-662-4357. Do not try to stop or withdraw on your own if that could make you sick. A doctor can help you do it safely, and a counselor can walk with you. Needing that help is not a failure. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988 in the United States, or tell someone near you right away.

What Scripture teaches

The psalm talks to a downcast soul and says, "Put your hope in God, for I will yet praise Him." "Yet" means the praise is not required before the hope. Mercies are new every morning, even after a night that felt final. The Lord is near the brokenhearted. You can approach Him for grace to help in time of need. He will strengthen and help you. These verses do not say you must feel okay in order to be helped. They say the feeling "nothing else will work" is not the last word.

> *"Why are you downcast, O my soul? Why the unease within me? Put your hope in God, for I will yet praise Him, my Savior and my God"* (Psalm 42:11).

Also see

> "Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!" (Lamentations 3:22–23).

> "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit" (Psalm 34:18).

> "Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need" (Hebrews 4:16).

> "Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness" (Isaiah 41:10).

Common self-statements

- This is the only thing that works.
- I have tried, and nothing else touches it.
- If I cannot feel hope, there is no hope.
- God has already decided not to help me.
- People who talk about other options do not know my pain.
- I might as well give up.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Deciding every future help will fail because this one worked fastest.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling hopeless and calling the feeling a fact about God and about medicine.

- All-or-nothing thinking: If this is what works, nothing else is allowed to count.
- Discounting the positive: Erasing every hour of relief that did not come from using.

Challenging questions

- What have I actually tried, and what have I only imagined would fail?
- Is “I cannot feel another way” the same as “no other way exists”?
- Who is one person or helper I have not given a real chance?
- What would I tell a friend who said nothing else will ever work?
- Where is God in the sentence “nothing else”?
- If I am thinking about dying, who will I tell today?

Truth summary

> This is not the only thing that can help me. God is near, other help exists, and I can ask even when I cannot feel that yet.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

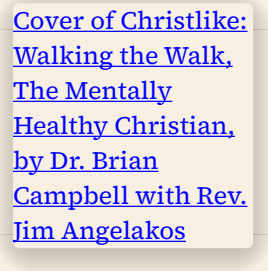
- Hopeless
- Depression, Symptoms of
- Help
- Joy
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Depression
- Prayer
- Thinking, Healthy

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



Cover of Christlike: Walking the Walk, The Mentally Healthy Christian, by Dr. Brian Campbell with Rev. Jim Angelakos

From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from “The Mentally Healthy Christian” (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Living hope is for the day when you cannot imagine another way to feel okay.

Forever — Kari Jobe
God's love outlasts the feeling that nothing else will work.

Hymn of Heaven — Phil Wickham
There is more ahead than the relief you can arrange tonight.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
You belong to Christ even when you feel unable to feel okay any other way.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "This is the only thing that makes me feel okay, and nothing else will work."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"This is the only thing that makes me feel okay, and nothing else will work." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What have I actually tried, and what have I only imagined would fail?
- ☐ Is "I cannot feel another way" the same as "no other way exists"?
- ☐ Who is one person or helper I have not given a real chance?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend who said nothing else will ever work?
- ☐ Where is God in the sentence "nothing else"?
- ☐ If I am thinking about dying, who will I tell today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ This is not the only thing that can help me. God is near, other help exists, and I can ask even when I cannot feel that yet.
- ☐ Feeling like nothing else will work is not proof that nothing will.
- ☐ I am allowed to want to feel okay.
- ☐ God is near me in this, not waiting for me to fix it first.
- ☐ A doctor, a counselor, and other people can help.
- ☐ I do not have to feel hopeful before I ask.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 42:11
  "Why are you downcast, O my soul? Why the unease within me? Put your hope in God, for I will yet praise Him, my Savior and my God."
- ☐ Lamentations 3:22–23
  "Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!"

☐ Psalm 34:18

"The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When nothing else seemed able to help: Each day, write down one moment when you felt this was the only way to feel okay. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 42:11 becomes: "James can write: "My soul is downcast, and I will yet hope in God. This is not my only help.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Hopeless" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. For help with substance use, call 1-800-662-4357, and talk with a doctor before you stop if withdrawal could make you sick.

- [ ] If you want to die, call or text 988 or tell someone near you now. Do that before any other step.
- [ ] Tell one helper the sentence "nothing else will work," and let them answer. A counselor, a doctor, or 1-800-662-4357.
- [ ] Do not stop suddenly to force another way to work. Ask a doctor what is safe.
- [ ] Read Psalm 42:11 out loud, including the word "yet."

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "This is the only thing that makes me feel okay, and nothing else will work.": _____ %

My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A help I did not dismiss
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~This is the only thing that makes me feel okay, and nothing else will work~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, my soul is downcast, and I have believed nothing else will work. You are my Savior and my God. Give me help I cannot feel yet, and keep me alive to receive it. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.